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Operation Blue Star

OPERATION BHINDRANWALE-Khalistan-2 (Op-2) had a predetermined goal, a fixed time frame and an operational plan. These three aspects have been explained in previous chapters. By 1984, the time had come to roll out the 'final solution'. The essential ingredients for justifying strong action had converged – or, were made to converge – by the end of May that year. A majority of the Indian population, an efficiently managed Indian press, observant foreign media and governments (through their missions in India) – everyone appeared to have been sufficiently convinced about the 'sincerity' of Indira Gandhi's prolonged efforts to find a negotiated settlement to the Punjab problem.

The carefully controlled chaos in Punjab could not be allowed to drift any further without the prime minister losing the confidence, and votes, of the majority community. According to government figures, Bhindranwale-inspired extremists had already killed 165 Hindus and Nirankaris in the twenty-two months since the launch of the Dharam Yudh Morcha in August 1982. In addition, thirty-nine Sikhs had been killed for opposing Bhindranwale. The total number of deaths in violent incidents, including the so-called police 'encounters', riots, and the accident at the railway level crossing in which thirty-four supporters of the morcha were killed, stood at 410, while the injured numbered 1,180. [1] The Congress had already lost a state-level by-election in Uttar Pradesh, a stronghold of the party.

Senior Akali Dal leaders, troubled by the PM's dilatory tactics, were feeling helpless and suffocated within the Golden Temple complex because of Bhindranwale's presence and his extremist